



Shaping your story

It takes time and planning to create an effective brand story. Begin by asking yourself what motivated you to start your business. Perhaps it was because you could not find something you wanted to buy so decided to make it yourself or because you were passionate about a particular product or service and excited to make it more widely available. Look beyond the potential financial rewards and consider what makes you excited about your business, and then jot down some words that express your emotional responses.

Think about your customers and clients. How would you like them to feel when they trade with you? What would you like them to say about your business? Note the answers to these questions and keep reviewing them. You can then weave the elements you have compiled into a positive and convincing brand story.



BE AWARE

- › **Do not** make false claims. If your story is not genuine, when the truth emerges, your customers will no longer trust you, and your brand will be damaged.
- › **Focus on** what makes your business different. Your story must be unique and stand apart from that of your competitors.
- › **Make sure** that daily operations live up to the story you tell your clients, and reflect the message behind your brand.
- › **Encourage colleagues** to understand and embrace your business's core message and the values you want to convey to your customers and clients.

TARGET YOUR AUDIENCE

Not everyone will be your customer or client, and not everyone will share your values, so tailor your story to those who will and do. Use the information you have gained about your market, and potential customers and clients (see pp.38–39), to target your brand story accordingly. For example, if you have identified that your customers or clients are likely to have families, weave a family element into your story.



SPREAD THE WORD

Share your brand story on the social media sites most used by your customers (see pp.140–141). If you have a website, post messages, images, and videos relating to your story on it. As you gain more customers and clients, actively engage with them to build closer relationships. Try to gain the support of online “influencers” who may share your story with their followers (see pp.198–199).

